TEAM LEADER ESSENTIALS

Team Leader Essentials — Day 3: Coaching and Feedback That Changes Behavior

Study guide · Self-study

Day 3: Coaching and Feedback That Changes Behavior

How to Use This Guide

This is Day 3 of Team Leader Essentials. You work through it alone, at your own pace, and you write in it as you go. Keep a pen or a notes file open: reading this guide will not change how you lead. Writing your own answers, then saying them out loud, will.

The guide follows a simple rhythm in every section: explain, example, reflect. Read the explanation, study the example, then do the reflection before you move on. Resist the urge to skim. The reflections are where the material becomes yours.

You were good at your job, and that is part of why you lead a team now or are preparing to. Coaching is a different skill. It is not pushing harder at your own team members, and it is not telling them what to do. It is asking questions that help them solve the problem themselves, so the next time it happens, they don't need you.

Day 1 covered the shift from top performer to leader, accountability and delegation. Day 2 covered clear expectations, the daily huddle and SBI (Situation, Behavior, Impact) feedback. Today builds on both. You will use SBI by name, and you will add two things: a question structure for coaching conversations, and a habit of feedback that is specific, timely and focused on behavior rather than personality.

Do the "What Would You Say?" exercises before you look at the Model Answers. The model answers are examples, not scripts. Your words should sound like you.

Today's Objectives (KASU)

Knowledge: You will know The Question Ladder and its 4 rungs, and why the Impact rung is the one most leaders skip.

Attitude: You will shift from being the person with the answers to being the person with the questions, and accept that a team member's own solution sticks better than yours.

Skill: You will be able to run a short coaching conversation using The Question Ladder, and give feedback that describes specific behavior and its impact rather than the person's character.

Upskill: You will record a five-minute coaching conversation, review it against The Question Ladder, and identify exactly where you slipped into telling instead of asking.

From Telling to Coaching

Most new team leaders coach the way they were coached: they give instructions. A team member brings a problem, the leader diagnoses it, prescribes a fix, and the conversation is over in ninety seconds. It feels efficient. It is also the reason the same problem comes back next week.

Here is the psychology of coaching. People commit to conclusions they reach themselves. When you hand someone an answer, they hear it as your instruction. They may follow it, but they don't own it. When they talk their way to the answer, they own it, and they defend it the way they defend their own ideas.

There is a second reason. When you always supply the answer, your team learns to wait for it. You become the bottleneck. The questions they should be asking themselves get routed to you instead. Coaching questions move that thinking back where it belongs.

The tension is real, and you will feel it. Telling is fast. Asking is slower in the moment and faster over the month. Your instinct, built over years of solving problems quickly yourself, will pull you toward the answer. Notice it. Name it to yourself. Then ask the next question.

Reflect: think of the last time a team member brought you a problem this week. Did you ask a question or give an answer? Write down what you actually said, as close to the words as you can remember.

The Question Ladder

The Question Ladder (MEDJAY adaptation, based on Rackham) is a four-rung question structure, climbed in order: Situation, Problem, Impact, Need. Impact is the rung most people skip.

Rung 1, Situation: what is the context? "What's the account? What stage is it at?" This rung is easy and most leaders do it well. Don't linger here. Situation questions gather facts; they don't yet create insight.

Rung 2, Problem: where is the pressure? "What's been hard so far?" This is where the team member starts to think out loud instead of reporting.

Rung 3, Impact: why does the problem matter? "What happens if that slips?" This is the rung most leaders skip. It is also the rung that does the work. When someone explains, in their own words, what a missed deadline costs the customer, the team or their own credibility, the problem stops being an item on a list and becomes something they care about fixing. A team member who has said the consequence out loud is far more likely to act on it than one who was told the consequence.

Rung 4, Need: what would help? "What would help most right now?" Here you finally let them name what they need from you, which may be advice, a decision, cover, or nothing at all. Notice the order. You ask what they need only after they have felt the weight of the problem. A Need question asked cold, at the start, gets a shrug.

Why the ladder works, in psychology terms: each rung raises the team member's own involvement in the problem. By the Need rung, the solution is half-built and half-owned before you have said anything. You are not persuading them to care. You are letting them hear themselves care.

Practice example: A team member, Priya, owns a mid-sized business account that has gone quiet. Situation: "Where does that account stand?" "They've stopped replying since the quote." Problem: "What's been hard about it?" "I don't know if the quote was too high or if it's just timing." Impact: "If it stays quiet another two weeks, what happens?" "We lose the quarter's target on that segment, and honestly it's the account I was proudest of winning." Need: "What would help most right now?" "A second pair of eyes on the quote before I follow up, and a nudge on when to call again." Notice how the Impact answer changed her tone. Nobody told her it mattered. She said it.

NOTES

A common mistake is jumping from Problem straight to your solution. That leap skips Impact and Need, and it turns the conversation back into an instruction. Another mistake is stacking two questions in one breath. Ask one, then stop talking.

Reflect: write your own four questions, in your own words, for a real team member and a real problem they have right now. Read them aloud. Which one feels hardest to ask? That is usually Impact.

Feedback on Behavior, Not Personality

You learned SBI (Situation, Behavior, Impact) on Day 2: describe the specific Situation, the observable Behavior and its Impact, then have the person practice. Today, use it as the engine of a coaching conversation.

The psychology behind it is simple. Feedback about personality ("you're careless," "you're not a details person") lands as a verdict on who someone is. There is nothing to act on and plenty to defend, so the person defends. Feedback about behavior ("the report arrived after the customer call had started") is a fact about an event. It is easier to hear, easier to check and easier to change.

Timeliness matters for the same reason. Memory of an event fades quickly, and so does the emotional charge around it. Feedback delivered the same day is about something both of you can still see. Feedback delivered three weeks later is about a story neither of you remembers the same way.

Watch the word "always" and the word "never." Both turn a behavior into a character trait. Drop them.

Practice example: A team member, Marcus, missed a deadline. Weak version: "You're always late with these and it's not acceptable. You need to be more reliable." Stronger version with SBI: "At yesterday's handover (Situation), the customer list arrived after the morning huddle had finished (Behavior), so two customers waited until after lunch for their first call (Impact). Walk me through how you'd sequence it next week (practice)." The first version invites an argument about whether he is always late. The second invites a plan.

Reflect: take a piece of feedback you gave recently and rewrite it as SBI. Cut every word that describes who the person is. Keep only what you saw and what followed.

Coaching After a Missed Deadline

Here is the whole skill in one conversation. A team member, Dana, missed a deadline that affected a customer. You are annoyed. Your first instinct is to tell her exactly what went wrong and how to fix it.

Hold that instinct, and climb the ladder.

Situation: "Walk me through the Henderson account and where it stands now."

Problem: "What got in the way this week?"

Impact: "The customer expected the update yesterday. What happens for them, and for us, if it slips another few days?"

Need: "What would help most now, and what will you do differently on the next one?"

Then close with a calibrated how or what question that asks for a commitment rather than a yes. "What would you need to see in place so the next handover lands a day early?" Or give a genuine choice: "Would you rather own the first call back to the customer today, or draft the revised timeline and I make the call with you?" Either way she chooses a real next step with a date attached.

What a weak close would sound like, for contrast only: "Okay, so you'll do better next time, right?" That asks for reassurance, not a plan. Don't do that.

Why this works: Dana came in expecting a telling-off, and probably braced for one. The questions interrupt that brace. By the time you reach Impact, she is the one explaining why the miss matters, which is a far stronger motivator than your disapproval. You still hold the standard. You just made her hold it with you. That is the goal you will practice Day 4 when underperformance becomes a pattern.

> **NOTES**
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> If the miss was caused by something you own (an unclear expectation, a late decision on your side), say so plainly before you ask. Coaching loses all credibility if you ask someone to name the obstacle and then punish them for naming you.
>
> Reflect: write the opening Situation question you would actually ask Dana. Then write the first thing your instinct wants to say instead. Circle which one you would rather be on the receiving end of.

Apply It in Your Role

You don't need a formal meeting to coach. You need a question and thirty seconds. Look for the small moments.

In a one-to-one: climb the full ladder. Start with Situation, don't skip Impact, end on Need. Give yourself permission to sit in silence after each rung.

At the daily huddle: ask one Impact question about the day's biggest priority. "What does it cost us if that call doesn't happen by noon?" It takes ten seconds and aligns the team around consequence, not instruction.

After a customer complaint: use SBI first, then the ladder. Describe what happened and its impact, then ask what would help and what they would change.

On a quick walk to the desk: use just Problem and Impact. Two questions are enough to turn a status update into a coaching moment.

With a top performer: the ladder still applies. Their Situation and Problem answers will be sharp. Your Impact question is what stretches them.

- ☐ Pick one team member and one live problem, and run the full ladder in your next conversation.
- ☐ Identify one piece of feedback you owe someone today and write it as SBI before you say it.

☐ Remove "always" and "never" from your feedback vocabulary this week.

☐ Note one moment where you gave an answer when a question would have done.

What Would You Say?

Write your answer to each before reading the Model Answers.

1. A team member, Tomas, missed a deadline that affected a customer. You have thirty seconds before he walks into your office. Write your opening Situation question.

2. Tomas answers that he was "busy with other accounts." Write your Problem question and your Impact question.

3. He says the real reason is that he didn't understand which account was the priority. You realize your expectation was unclear. Write what you say next, using the ladder.

4. Another team member keeps sending incomplete customer records. You need to give feedback today, not in three weeks. Write it in SBI.

5. A team member asks you directly, "Just tell me what to do and I'll do it." Write your answer that keeps coaching alive without being preachy.

Key Takeaways

- Coaching is asking questions that help a team member solve the problem, not giving instructions. People commit to conclusions they reach themselves.
- The Question Ladder has 4 rungs climbed in order: Situation, Problem, Impact, Need.
- Impact is the rung most leaders skip, and it is the rung that does the work. It gets the team member to say, in their own words, why the problem matters.
- Feedback lands when it is specific, timely and about behavior. SBI keeps it observable and gives the person something to act on.
- Personality feedback ("you're careless") creates defense. Behavior feedback ("the report arrived after the call") creates a plan.
- A missed deadline is a coaching opportunity. Climb the ladder, then close with a calibrated how or what question, or a genuine choice with a date.

Quiz

Answer all 5 questions. Write your answer first, then check the notes.

1. What is the purpose of a coaching conversation?

A. To correct the team member quickly so the problem doesn't repeat

B. To help the team member reach and own the solution through questions

C. To demonstrate your expertise so the team trusts your judgment

D. To document the conversation for future reference

2. Which rung of The Question Ladder do most leaders skip?

   A. Situation

   B. Problem

   C. Impact

   D. Need

3. A team member, Ana, sends a customer proposal with the pricing section missing. Which is the strongest feedback?

   A. "You're careless with details, and you need to raise your game."

   B. "At yesterday's review (S), the proposal went out with no pricing (B), and the customer had to ask for it before they could decide (I). Let's practice the final check together."

   C. "I noticed you've been a bit off lately. Is everything okay?"

   D. "You always forget something. Let's put a checklist on your wall."

4. You have just heard the Impact answer and the team member is silent. What should you do?

   A. Fill the silence with your own solution

   B. Move to the Need question immediately

   C. Ask a yes/no question to keep momentum

   D. Let the silence sit, then ask the Need question

5. Why is the Impact question so powerful in a coaching conversation?

   A. It lets you state the consequence for the team member

   B. It gathers the facts you need to make a decision

   C. It makes the team member explain the consequence in their own words, which builds ownership

   D. It shortens the conversation so you can get back to selling

Upskill Challenge

Record a five-minute coaching conversation with a team member about a real issue, with their agreement. You can use any phone or video tool. It does not need to be polished. If recording is not possible, take detailed notes during the conversation and write them up immediately afterward.

Run the full Question Ladder and close with a calibrated how or what question, or a genuine choice with a date. Then review the recording or your notes against this list.

☐ Did I open with a Situation question and keep it brief?

☐ Did I ask at least one Problem question?

☐ Did I ask an Impact question, and did the team member answer it in their own words?

☐ Did I ask a Need question, and wait for the answer?

☐ Did I slip into telling at any point? Mark the exact moment.

☐ Did my close ask for a next step with a date, not a yes?

☐ Was my feedback, if any, in SBI and about behavior, not personality?

Write down the one moment where you told instead of asked. That moment is your practice target for Day 4.

If you do not lead a team yet, coach a peer or a newer colleague who asks you for help, with their agreement.

Model Answers

These are examples, not scripts. Keep the principle; use your own words.

1. Opening Situation question. "Tomas, walk me through the Henderson account and where it stands right now." Keep it short, factual and easy to answer.

2. Problem and Impact. Problem: "What got in the way this week?" Impact: "The customer expected the update yesterday. What happens for them, and for us, if it slips another few days?" Notice you ask, you don't state the consequence for him.

3. Ownership of the unclear expectation. "That's on me, then. I wasn't clear about which account came first." Then back to the ladder: "What would help most now, and what should I do differently so the priority is obvious next time?" You own your part and keep him thinking.

4. SBI feedback, delivered the same day. "At this morning's handover (Situation), several customer records came through with the contact section empty (Behavior), so the team had to call each customer twice to get details we already had (Impact). Let's practice filling one together now (practice)."

5. Keeping coaching alive. "I could tell you, and I will if you want. First, one question: what do you think the first step is?" If they still want the answer, give it, briefly, then ask: "What would help you spot the next one yourself?" Refusing to answer at all is not coaching; it's withholding.

- Quiz answers:
- 1. B. Coaching is about helping someone reach and own the solution; telling them the answer is instruction, not coaching.
- 2. C. Most leaders stop at Situation or jump from Problem to a solution, skipping Impact.
- 3. B. It uses SBI: a specific situation, observable behavior, its impact, and a practice step. A and D attack character; C is vague.
- 4. D. Silence gives the person room to think and to own the answer; filling it hands them a narrower question.
- 5. C. The team member explains the consequence in their own words, which is why it drives action where your telling would not.

References

Rackham, N. (1988). SPIN Selling. McGraw-Hill.

Center for Creative Leadership (CCL). SBI (Situation, Behavior, Impact) feedback model.